



Eight and knocked New Zealand out. The fans were serenaded before the start of play as Calypso legend David Rudder sang Rally, Rally 'Round the West Indies. The stirring anthem was released in 1987 but adopted as the team's 'national' anthem in 1999, coinciding with the onset of a downward spiral that would afflict the West Indies for a decade.

The Diary can say from first-hand experience that despite the concern of many about the state of West Indian cricket, the fans in the Caribbean truly believe that this is the year their team wins a record third T20 World Cup title.

West Indies skipper Rovman Powell talked about it before the tournament began. "It's very special, to be honest, not just for me but for the other players and for the people of the Caribbean — the possibility of winning a third World Cup title in front of our own people in the Caribbean is something very, very special," he said at a press

interaction. "For us as players, it's a legacy. It's something that, after we finish playing, we can sit down and tell our kids and grandkids, our family, and just replay those memories of 2024.

"Also, from a financial standpoint, we know the standard of West Indies cricket, and it would be a massive boost for us to win the World Cup. So all that money that comes with winning the World Cup can be filtered down into our youth programme and help benefit West Indies cricket."

No team has ever won the T20 World Cup on home soil before, but Powell's men seem determined to break that hoodoo. The final will be played in Barbados on June 29, the land of Worrell, Weekes and Walcott, at a ground with stands named after Desmond Haynes and Gordon Greenidge. A happy communion of past, present and future would be the perfect ode to West Indies cricket.

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Den of the king: Scenes from the stadium in Trinidad and Tobago, the kingdom of the cricketing prince, Brian Charles Lara. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



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